'the number of registered crimes against the interests of the service in commercial and other organisations has almost tripled', while the detection rate for fraud committed by business executives had increased by a staggering 74% (Interfax 2012). Meantime, corruption in Russia is not only associated with activities such as embezzlement or bribes (worth as much as US$300 billion yearly), but, much more worryingly, relates closely to the penetration by organised crime of every level of the state administration (Dawisha 2014:8).

To give but one example from the Russian capital, a cable dispatched from the US's Moscow embassy recounted how 'criminal elements enjoy a *krysha* [literally meaning 'roof' – crimespeak for 'protection'] that runs through the police, the Federal Security Service, the Ministry of Internal Affairs and the prosecutor's office'. According to the document, the then mayor of Moscow (Yury Luzhkov, unceremoniously sacked by President Medvedev shortly after the leak, though not because of it) oversaw the whole criminal structure (Chanche 2010; see also WikiLeaks 2010; Pozo-Martin 2013). Even beyond Moscow, corruption in Russia is ubiquitous and, according to Shlapentokh (2012:157), is largely accepted by ordinary citizens as normal; by now they would only expect a clear and stable sense of how these unwritten rules work.

Russia's population crisis and the effects of corruption might offer enough gloom on their own, but they must still be considered alongside a further element setting Russia quite apart from the other BICS (and also dampening its future): the economy's high degree of dependence on hydrocarbon and, to a certain extent, on other mineral resources, which underscores its 'peripheral' status and its vulnerability to cycles of boom and bust in commodity prices. The years 2000–8 (those of Putin's first two terms as president) saw an almost continuous rise in international oil prices (from just over US$20 a barrel to the historic record price of US$140). At the same time, the Russian economy recorded a miraculous economic recovery. GDP grew in 2000 by 10% (of course, the economy had just come from a drastic slump – the rouble crisis – in 1998), and continued to expand by an average of 4–5% until 2008. Living standards followed the same trend (average GDP per capita rose from US$1778.7 in 2000 to US$9062 in 2008; while unemployment fell from 10.5% to 6.3% in the same period).

By 2008 the Russian state had fulfilled its debt obligations with the West, accumulated over half a trillion dollars in foreign reserves and overseen the creation of two sovereign wealth funds which would, it was hoped, guarantee social coverage and economic stability through periods of hardship. Even more importantly, the good years saw positive developments beyond the hallmarks of an oil boom: there was also a sharp increase in consumer spending, a surge